

DATA INTRODUCTION

Immigration and Customs Enforcement Individual-Level Administrative Data

Graeme Blair* David Hausman[†] Phil Neff[‡]

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Abstract

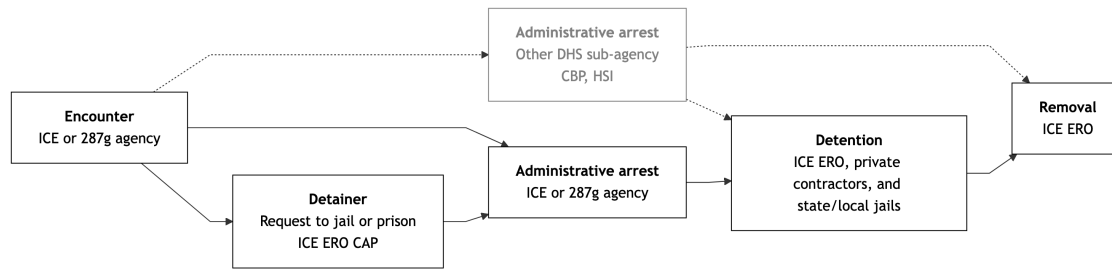
This dataset, based on records obtained by Freedom of Information Act request, tracks United States Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) individual enforcement actions from September 2023 through July 2025. The dataset includes five tables, linked by anonymized individual identifiers, tracking ICE encounters, detainer requests, arrests, detentions, and removals. The dataset creates new opportunities for descriptive and causal research on recent changes in immigration enforcement policy in the United States.

*Professor of Political Science, UCLA, and Co-Director of the Deportation Data Project.

[†]Assistant Professor of Law, University of California–Berkeley School of Law, and Co-Director of the Deportation Data Project.

[‡]Research Coordinator, University of Washington Center for Human Rights

Figure 1: Illustration of the stages of the ICE immigration enforcement process and what is contained in the dataset.



Note: black indicates data included in the dataset; gray indicates not included. ERO is ICE’s Enforcement and Removal Operations unit; CAP is ICE’s Criminal Alien Program; CBP is the Customs and Border Protection agency; HSI is the Homeland Security Investigations agency; and 287(g) refers to agreements between ICE and local law enforcement agencies to cooperate on immigration enforcement.

1. Background and summary

Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), the agency that arrests, detains, and departs noncitizens within the United States, does not proactively release individual-level data on its actions. Such data is, however, public information, and is available by Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request. We present a new version of that dataset, obtained by the Deportation Data Project (which two of us co-direct) through FOIA litigation, that includes every ICE encounter, detainer request, arrest, book-in to detention, and deportation from September 2023 through the end of July 2025. The dataset is drawn from data that ICE collects for its own operational purposes and therefore represents the government’s own understanding of its enforcement actions. As with all administrative data, we urge users to exercise caution in analysis and interpretation of the data, but we believe that the data are accurate at the level of broad trends, and in the following we describe validation checks undertaken to confirm their accuracy.

The dataset tracks five key enforcement actions that ICE takes. First, it tracks encounters: any in-person or virtual contact with a person ICE believes might be eligible for enforcement action; these include records of automated fingerprint matches after someone is booked into a jail or prison. Second, the dataset tracks detainer requests: requests by ICE for a jail or prison to detain noncitizens beyond their release dates to allow ICE to arrest them (and/or to notify ICE of dates and times of release). Third, the dataset tracks ICE arrests: apprehensions that ICE conducts either in jails and prisons or at large of people it charges with civil violations of U.S. immigration law. Fourth, the dataset tracks detentions: each time that ICE books someone into or out of a detention center or hold room. Finally, the dataset tracks ICE removals: each time that ICE forcibly removes someone from the United States, whether pursuant to a removal order or a grant of voluntary departure.

Because the dataset includes each of these key enforcement actions, it allows users to assemble a comprehensive portrait of immigration enforcement by ICE in the United States. This use is critical for both research and policy at a time when immigration enforcement policies and practices are rapidly changing.

The Deportation Data Project recently obtained this dataset; here, we make the dataset available for academic researchers. Limited parts of this dataset have been sporadically available in the past.¹

¹See, for example, dashboard tools created by the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse or TRAC (tracreports.org/immigration); as well as datasets assembled from public records described in Ryo and Peacock (2018), Ryo and Peacock (2020), and University of Washington Center for Human Rights (2024).

The dataset presented here, and the accompanying documentation we provide, makes several key new contributions. First, this dataset includes anonymized unique identifiers that correspond to individuals' A-numbers, the federal government identity number for noncitizens. The anonymized IDs allow analysis following individuals across enforcement actions, from encounter to arrest to detention to eventual deportation. These identifiers are available following years of litigation that one of us participated in, culminating in a decision by the Second Circuit Court of Appeals requiring their release. Second, this dataset includes more information than past ICE data, with five tables, each of which tracks a different enforcement action: encounters, detainers, arrests, detentions, and removals (deportations). Third, this dataset is, to our knowledge, the only individual-level dataset tracking enforcement since the beginning of 2025 – a fact that has led to widespread media use of the dataset and that also creates a wide variety of opportunities for academic research (see Usage Notes).² Fourth, we conduct validation checks on the dataset and assemble a codebook for it. Finally, we produce a more user-friendly version of the detentions dataset, allowing users to conduct analysis at the detention stay level immediately, skipping a difficult data cleaning step. As a result, the detentions table is available in two versions, one that includes the original data and a second that is simplified; more details below.

2. Methods

This dataset is the result of a Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request filed by the Center for Immigration Law and Policy in May 2024 (CILP v ICE, No. 2:24-cv-10444 (C.D. Cal.)).³ After ICE did not respond to the request for six months, CILP filed a lawsuit in the U.S. District Court for the Central District of California in December 2024 to compel the release of the data. The dataset described here was sent from ICE's FOIA office on a DVD with a letter describing the contents dated August 7, 2025.

In addition to providing the original data as we received it, we minimally processed the data for the arrests, detainers, and removals tables to facilitate analysis. We converted each field to the appropriate data type, for example casting birth years as integers and removing putative time information from date-time fields when all times were recorded as "00:00:00." We renamed a small number of columns to shorten them to enable saving in data formats that have limits on variable name length. No rows were added or subtracted.

We also removed several columns that contained no information, either because they were blank or contained only government redaction codes. There were two reasons for redaction: personally-identifiable information such as names of noncitizens or government employees, which are exempt from disclosure under FOIA Exemptions 6 and 7(C); and internal agency case numbers, which fall under Exemption 7(E).

In addition, we added an indicator for potentially duplicated observations, enabling analysts to optionally exclude these records from analyses. There are several types of potential duplicates across the different tables and multiple reasonable approaches to resolving them. Some records are exact duplicates across all fields and can be dropped. Others involve multiple entries for the same noncitizen in the same 24-hour period, and it is unclear whether these reflect repeated enforcement actions, administrative corrections, or errors. Arrests provide a useful example: a small number of rows are identical across all fields, while a larger number involve more than one arrest of the same individual on the same apprehension date. Many of these appear to stem from administrative updates, such as rows marked "E-Charging Document Canceled by

²See <https://deportationdata.org/news.html> for examples of media use of the dataset.

³See <https://deportationdata.org/foia.html> for details.

ICE.” In some rare cases, these patterns may reflect multiple enforcement actions within a short window, but most reflect duplicates recorded for administrative reasons, such as when a record is corrected after initial data entry.

We took several additional steps to process the detentions data to facilitate analysis. The detentions data are provided by ICE in a more complex format than the other tables. In the original ICE data, there is a row for every book-in to a particular detention center (we use the term “stint” to refer to this level of analysis), but many research questions about detention concern what ICE calls an individual’s “stay” in detention — a single period of detention for a single person that often includes transfers between detention centers. We produce two datasets, one at the stint level and one at the stay level.

For the stay-level dataset, we create a dataset that has a single row for each stay in detention, preserving most (but not all) of the information in the original dataset. Individuals can have more than one stay in detention if they are released and later detained again; in that case, this dataset includes a row for each stay.⁴

We construct the dataset in three steps. First, we remove 1,494 rows (of 1,323,993 total) for which there is a missing unique identifier. For these individuals, we are not able to convert stints into stays.

Second, we identify duplicate stint records, which exist in cases where the bond amount set by the agency changed.⁵ In the stint-level dataset, we construct a duplicate indicator field, flagging records with initial bond amounts above the smallest bond amount across otherwise duplicate stints; we drop these 4,099 duplicate records in our stay-level dataset.⁶

Third, we construct a dataset that consists of stay-level variables that are unchanging, including final order date, most serious conviction, and citizenship country. For fields whose values do change over stints – such as book-in and book out dates and the detention facility name – we provide variables with the values from the first, last, and longest stints in each stay, which are typically the most relevant for analysis.⁷ Analysts can modify our code and draw on the stint-level dataset to create alternative formulations of the stay-level dataset.

3. Data Records

In addition to providing the original Excel files provided by ICE, the processed data is made available in several file formats, including Excel, Feather, Stata, and SPSS data files. There are six tables in the dataset, including two versions of the original detentions table. Each table is distributed as a separate file. Submission versions of the data are deposited with the Harvard Dataverse; any updates will be made available at the Deportation Data Project website, deportationdata.org. We describe each table briefly here and in the Supplementary Materials include a detailed description of each field.

⁴Repeated stays are (anonymously) identifiable by the unique IDs in the data.

⁵The records are identical except in the bond amount, suggesting an error in the data extraction script used by the agency.

⁶We retain the smaller bond amount because we expect bond amounts to decrease more often than they increase. The decision affects a proportionally small number of observations in the stay-level data, and the original stint-level data remains available to users who wish to investigate bond amounts.

⁷Where a stay involves only one stint, these values are all identical. The values for the longest stint fields may also be identical to the first or last fields for stays with more than one stint.

3.1. Arrests table

The arrests table records every time ICE arrests someone, whether or not that arrest results in a decision to detain the person. Individuals appear more than once in the dataset if they are arrested more than once.

3.2. Detainers table

The detainers table records all detainer requests to federal, state, county, and municipal jails and prisons either for a person to be held on a detainer or for a notification of release date and time. A detainer is a request to a local jail to hold someone for 48 hours beyond when they otherwise would be released so that ICE can make an arrest in the jail while the individual remains detained.

3.3. Detentions table

The structure of the detention table is more complex than that of the other tables. Each row in the original ICE detentions tables represents a single period in detention at a single detention center; we call such a period a “stint.” Some noncitizens have only one stint per stay in detention, but many are transferred between detention centers during a single stay.

To illustrate the data structure of the detentions table, we take two noncitizens as examples:

- Noncitizen A is detained from March 19 to March 21. They have a single stint in Otero County Processing Center. They have one stay and one stint within the stay.
- Noncitizen B is detained once, from June 6 to July 9, but during their stay in detention they are transferred between three facilities. They have a first stint at the Los Angeles ICE hold room (“LOS CUST CASE”) from June 6 to June 7, then they are transferred to Adelanto ICE Processing Center and held there from June 7 to July 25, and finally they are transferred to Desert View Annex and held there from July 25 to July 9. Noncitizen B has one stay with three stints.

These two citizens’ stays in ICE detention would be represented in the stint level dataset as in Table 1a. The two noncitizens’ stays in ICE detention would be represented in the stay level dataset instead as just two rows, as in Table 1b.

3.3.1. Detention stints table

The detention stints dataset records each detention from book-in to book-out at a given detention center for a given individual; most individuals have more than one row in the table because they are transferred between detention centers.

3.3.2. Detention stays table.

The detention stays table, which we created from the stints table, logs each stay in ICE detention, from book in to the first facility to book out from the last facility for a given stay. A stay represents one or more stints in different facilities. Individuals may also be detained more than once and therefore have more than one stay in detention. Fields present in this table but not in the detention stints table were created by the authors to facilitate analysis as described above.

Table 1: Illustration of the structure of the detentions tables in the dataset.**(a) The detention stints table has one row per noncitizen’s detention in a particular facility.**

	Noncitizen ID	Stint ID	Stay dates		Stint dates		Detention facility
			Book-in	Book-out	Book-in	Book-out	
Stay 1	A	1	Mar. 19	Mar. 21	Mar. 19	Mar. 21	Otero Co Processing Center
Stay 2	B	1	Jun. 6	Jul. 9	Jun. 6	Jun. 7	Los Cust Case
	B	2	Jun. 6	Jul. 9	Jun. 7	Jun. 25	Adelanto ICE Processing Center
	B	3	Jun. 6	Jul. 9	Jun. 25	Jul. 9	Desert View Annex

(b) The detention stays table has one row per instance of custody by ICE, including transfers between one or more facilities.

		Noncitizen ID	Stay dates		# of Stints
			Book-in	Book-out	
Stay 1	A		Mar. 19	Mar. 21	1
Stay 2	B		Jun. 6	Jul. 9	3

3.4. Encounters table

The encounters table records every time ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations encounters a person, i.e. considers whether to take enforcement action against a person. This need not mean a physical encounter. Most notably, every time ICE processes a match between FBI book-in information (i.e. to a jail or prison) and ICE database information, that match is logged as an ICE encounter. Generally, if an individual appears in the detainees or arrests table, that individual should appear in this table. An individual might appear in the removals or detentions tables without appearing in the encounters data if Customs and Border Protection initially encountered the person. This is both the largest and the sparsest of the tables, and in many cases, encounters lack a unique ID because the individual lacked an A number (A numbers are generally only given to people with immigrant visas or when they are processed for deportation proceedings).

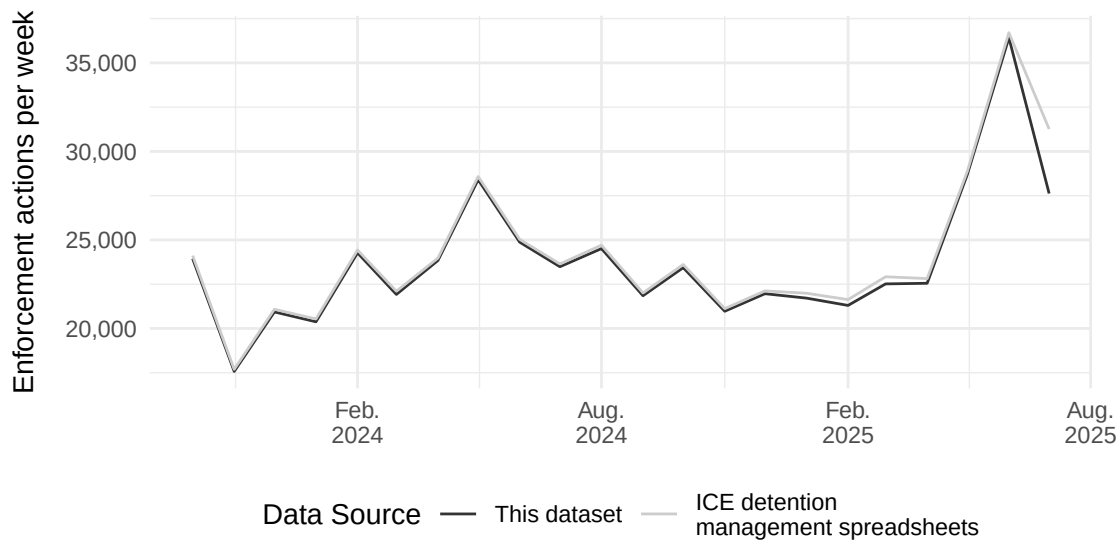
3.5. Removals table

The removals table records every deportation that ICE conducts, with a row for each individual deportation. An individual only has more than one row if that individual was deported more than once. Note that some border removals may be conducted by CBP without ICE involvement.

4. Technical Validation

There is not a ground truth source for the number of arrests, detainer requests, detention stays, or removals by US government immigration agencies. Instead, we treat the data as representing the government’s internal view of these numbers. To validate the data, we compare to government publications that draw on the same datasets, but because these publications do not provide replication archives or detailed methodology descriptions, we are unable to replicate them precisely.

Figure 2: No substantial difference between counts of detention book-ins between the dataset and the ICE “Detention Management Spreadsheet” posted fortnightly.



First, we compare the data to statistics from the ICE annual report for 2024, which represents the agency’s most vetted numbers. We identified three counts that can be compared: the total number of arrests, detainer requests, and removals. We calculated these counts using our dataset for the period from September 1, 2023, to October 31, 2024, representing fiscal year 2024. For arrests and detainer requests, the counts in the dataset are within 3,000 (<2%) of the report. Arrests are 113,431 in the annual report and 111,953 in the dataset, a difference of 1,478. Detainer requests are reported as 149,764 in the annual report and 146,953 in the dataset, a difference of 2,811. For removals, the difference remains under 5%; the annual report notes 271,484 removals compared to 282,214 in the dataset, a difference of 10,730.

Second, we compare counts from our detentions dataset to counts that ICE produces annually and biweekly, as required by Congress.⁸ The total number of individuals booked into detention each month in our dataset is within 2% and in most months within 1% of the counts provided by ICE. Figure 2 depicts the comparison.

Third, we compare our dataset to a past individual-level data release from ICE, which overlaps for one month, September 2023. We compare the daily counts for the month for each of the three overlapping tables: arrests, detentions, and removals. The number of book-ins to detention facilities is exactly in line, and the counts for arrests and removals are very close (see Figure 3). The median difference was 7% (arrests), 0.3% (detention book ins), and 5% (removals).

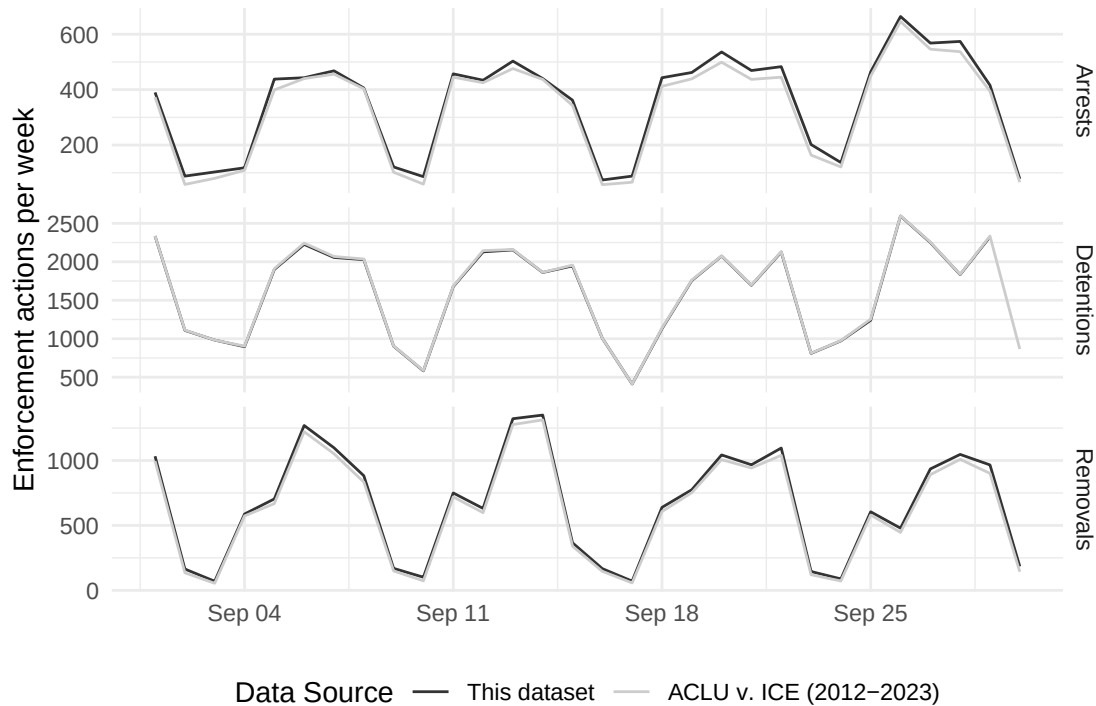
We also take two other validation steps that use only our own dataset.

First, we plot trends in enforcement activities across the five tables in our dataset (see Figure 4). Encounters have increased since late 2023 and are consistently the most common type of enforcement event. The sudden increase in early 2024 reflects an increase in “Non-Detained Docket Control” event types; the timing roughly follows the introduction of the ICE Portal in November 2023, a new website that, according to the 2024 ICE annual report, “centralizes communications between non-detained noncitizens and the federal government.”⁹ Detainers, arrests, initial detention book-ins, and removals were largely stable through the later period of

⁸<https://www.ice.gov/detain/detention-management>

⁹<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/eoy/iceAnnualReportFY2024.pdf>

Figure 3: No substantial difference between counts of enforcement actions between the dataset and past data released by ICE for overlapping month.



the Biden administration; all forms of enforcement activities with the exception of removals show a marked increase with the start of the second Trump administration in January 2025; arrests, detentions, and removals increase again during early summer 2025. These trends conform broadly to known policy shifts and do not show any obvious discontinuities which would suggest data issues.¹⁰ Trends appear to display minimal annual seasonality with the exception of a slight lull in enforcement during late December and early January.

Second, we show the extent to which the various tables intersect, or in other words, how frequently the same individuals appear in each (see Figure 5).¹¹

The above figure represents the coincidence of unique identifier values across five minimally-processed datasets: encounters, detainers, arrests, detentions (detention stints and stays are interchangeable here as they include identical sets of unique identifiers), and removals. (Set intersections with fewer than 10,000 observations are excluded from the figure.)

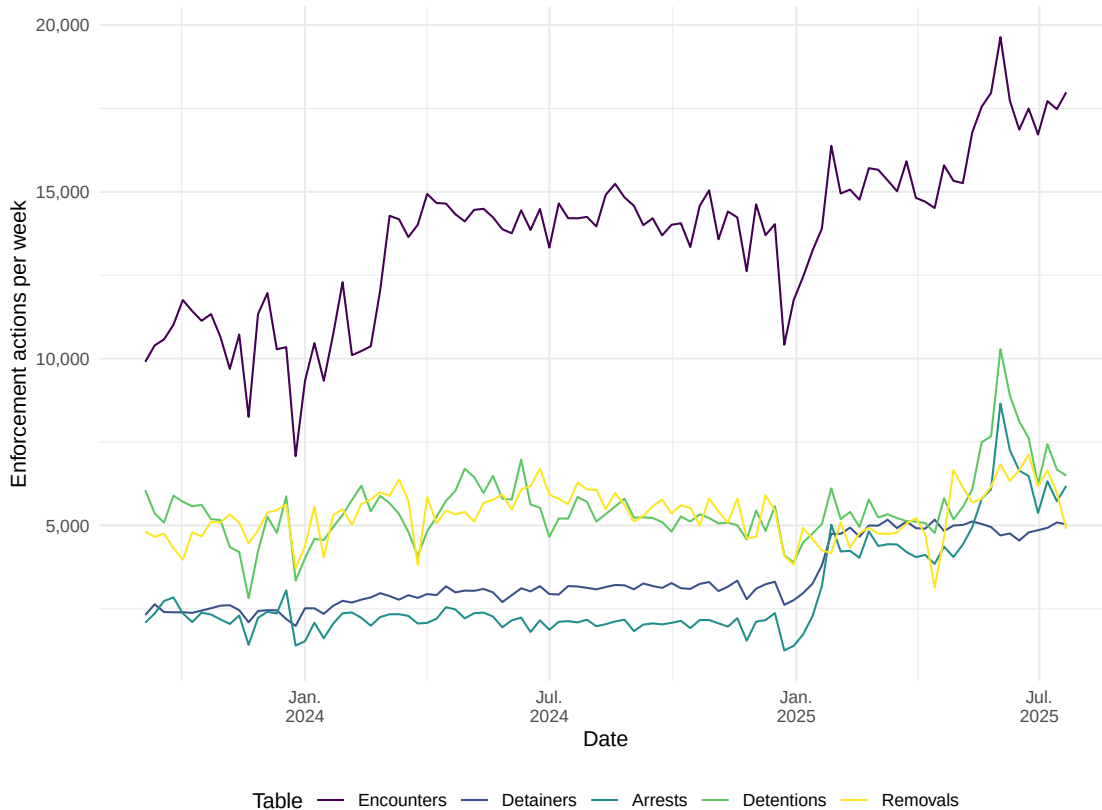
The largest dataset by total unique identifiers is encounters, followed by detentions, removals, arrests, and detainers. This hierarchy appears logical given what is known about ICE enforcement activity: encounters include surveillance activities which in most cases do not result in subsequent enforcement actions; detentions and removals include people apprehended by CBP and therefore may not be associated with other ICE enforcement actions; many but not all arrests proceed from detainers.

These validation checks suggest that the datasets are broadly reliable. That does not mean, of course, that they are error-free. Since much of the data is entered by people by hand, individual

¹⁰See for example our data update discussing validation of the removals dataset: <https://deportationdata.org/news/2025-09-29-update-ICE-removals.html>

¹¹Records lacking anonymized identifiers are excluded from analysis here.

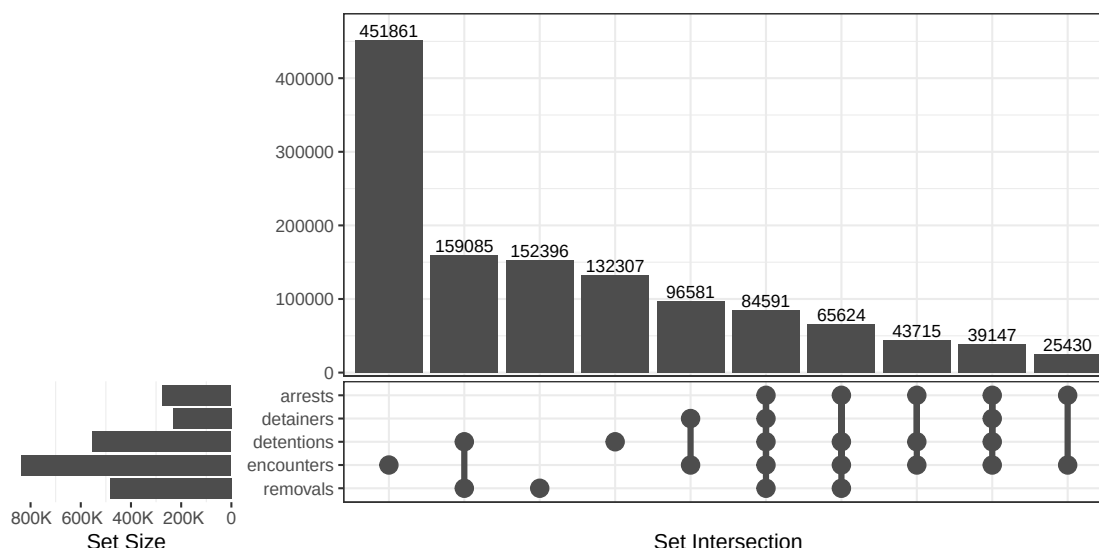
Figure 4: No unexpected spikes or dips in weekly trends in ICE enforcement actions in five tables in the dataset.



errors are likely. And a few types of individual errors may lead to systematic biases. For example, ICE officers may categorize an individual’s criminality as including a pending charge if that officer feels that the person could be charged with a crime, even if no charge is recorded.

An additional limitation is that these ICE datasets, while they cover large, important parts of the U.S. federal immigration enforcement system, do not cover all of it. The records reflect enforcement actions taken by ICE’s Enforcement and Removal Operations unit, and not by any other agency. They do not cover actions by Customs and Border Protection (CBP), which is responsible for arrests, inadmissibility determinations, short-term detentions, and some removals at or near the international borders and in some cases in the interior of the country. However, the actions are connected between the two agencies: CBP arrestees who are not either removed quickly or released are transferred to ICE custody for detention, and so then do appear in the detentions tables. Researchers studying border enforcement should consult the CBP datasets on encounters and inadmissibility determinations, which are released separately and at different intervals. The data also do not cover immigration enforcement actions carried out by Homeland Security Investigations (HSI), which principally conducts investigations and criminal arrests, but is empowered to make civil arrests. Finally, some federal agencies outside of the Department of Homeland Security participate in immigration enforcement actions, especially since January 20, 2025, including the FBI. These arrests may not be covered in this dataset, but like for CBP arrests these individuals may then appear in the detentions dataset if they are transferred to ICE custody.

Figure 5: The overlap of individuals appearing in one or more tables in the dataset is in line with what is known about the logic of ICE enforcement activity.



Note: Set intersections with fewer than 10,000 observations are not displayed.

5. Usage Notes

The five tables allow individual noncitizens to be traced anonymously through the ICE enforcement system from encounter to removal, with some caveats. Identifiers are not available for all records: people without Alien Registration Numbers (A-numbers) — such as some recent arrivals, arrestees who are undocumented, and U.S. citizens — lack a unique ID. Records without unique identifiers cannot be linked reliably across tables, and analyses requiring longitudinal tracking or linking enforcement actions for the same individual should exclude such cases or treat them separately. Typically, in later stages of the process recorded in the data, such as detention following an arrest without an ID, the noncitizen will be issued an A-number and so in that second record there will be a unique ID. However, the earlier table may not be updated.

Understanding the starting point to a noncitizen’s interactions with immigration authorities is nontrivial, and only some entry points are covered in the dataset explicitly. As noted, only encounters and arrests by ICE are recorded in this dataset. There are two key types of ICE arrests: custodial and noncustodial. Custodial arrests typically stem from detainer requests sent to jails and prisons, recorded in the detainers table in this dataset. The antecedents of noncustodial arrests vary; the Apprehension Method field in the arrests table only provides vague categories. Analysis of custodial arrests may draw both on the detainers and arrests tables. The datasets do not include information on whether local jails or prisons in fact held individuals for up to 48 hours pursuant to an ICE detainer request. Some “sanctuary jurisdictions” do not honor detainer requests by policy; others may not be honored for other reasons. The “Detainer Lift Reason” field does record several values that plausibly indicate detainer outcomes, including codes consistent with detainer refusals (“Detainer Declined by LEA”) or apparent acceptances (“Booked into Detention”). This field, however, is missing in a substantial share of records. Missing values may reflect that the individual remained in criminal custody, that the detainer was not honored, or that ICE had not yet updated the record at the time of release. The most reliable method for assessing whether an individual was transferred to ICE custody after a detainer request is to

link detainers to the detentions table by unique ID. Individuals who appear in the detainers table but not in the detentions table may not have been transferred to ICE custody. Those who appear in both tables were booked into ICE detention, usually following the detainer request. Importantly, people who do not appear in the detentions table might still remain in criminal custody and later be transferred to ICE custody; therefore, absence from the detentions table should not be interpreted as unambiguous evidence of release.

In tracing these pathways, researchers may wish to associate enforcement actions with physical locations. This is possible to varying degrees of geographic specificity. All actions can be attributed to one of 25 ICE field offices, representing varying amounts of the country from a small number of counties to several states. Arrests can be attributed to a state in most cases, but the field is missing for others. Encounters and arrests can also be attributed to a landmark, which is rarely missing but often reports non-geographic information or a generic location associated with a field office's entire area of responsibility. For detentions, location information is more straightforward to obtain: each detention record includes the specific facility of detention. However, the number of detention sites is relatively small, meaning analysis by location will still be coarse, and location information may be lacking for some detention facilities.

Once in ICE civil detention, many researchers may wish to study questions about the duration of detention, the number of transfers between facilities and the distances between them, and other aspects of the stays themselves. Some of these questions can be answered with the stint-level detention data, as originally provided by ICE; many require analyses at the stay level, which our stay level dataset facilitates. Counting the number of people held on a given day for any period of time at a given facility requires careful analysis of the stint-level data. Counting the number of people in ICE detention, irrespective of facility, however, requires analysis of the stay-level data.

Similar considerations apply to analysis of removals. The removals table includes information such as the "Docket AOR" responsible for the removal, and the "Port of Departure" where the deportation occurred; the port of departure may fall outside the geographic bounds of the Docket AOR. Cases where an individual's country of citizenship differs from the "Departure Country" may indicate third country removals.

6. Data Availability

The data used in this paper will be deposited in the Harvard Dataverse upon publication. The most up-to-date versions are at deportationdata.org/docs/ice/processing.html and github.com/deportationdata/ice.

7. Code Availability

All code used to produce the publication version of the data will be deposited at the Harvard Dataverse upon publication and the most up-to-date versions are at deportationdata.org/docs/ice/processing.html and github.com/deportationdata/ice.

8. References

Ryo, E. and I. Peacock (2018). A national study of immigration detention in the united states. *S. Cal. L. Rev.* 92, 1.

Ryo, E. and I. Peacock (2020). Jailing immigrant detainees: A national study of county participation in immigration detention, 1983–2013. *Law & Society Review* 54(1), 66–101.

University of Washington Center for Human Rights (2024, September). The border is everywhere: Immigration enforcement in the contemporary pacific northwest. Report.

9. Competing Interests

Blair has worked as an expert witness in cases involving analysis of ICE data for immigrants' rights organizations, but has received no remuneration. Hausman worked for the American Civil Liberties Union Immigrants' Rights Project as an attorney from 2016 to 2019 and briefly as a volunteer attorney in early 2025. He continues to consult occasionally for the ACLU and other immigrants' rights organizations. He also serves on the academic advisory board of the Acacia Center for Justice. Neff does not have any competing interests.

10. Acknowledgments

We thank the Center for Immigration Law and Policy at UCLA for submitting and litigating the case for the data that is presented here, Amber Qureshi and Michael Levin-Gesundheit for representing them in the case, the University of Washington Center for Human Rights for the time for Neff to work on the project, and Elena Gonzalez, Sofia Granados Sotelo, Claudia Liss-Schultz, Lorena Ortega Guerrero, and Alex Stratton for comments on the field descriptions.

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12. Ethics Statement

The data presented in this article are anonymized, and do not represent human subjects research.

Supplementary Materials

ICE does not provide documentation of records it releases under FOIA, so we have compiled a codebook for the dataset ourselves, drawing on previous research, public records, and our own experience with the data. Below, we first present a list of fields that are used in more than one of the tables and then present a list, for each table, of fields that are unique to that table.

A regularly-updated version of this codebook is available at deportationdata.org.

SM. 1 Fields in multiple datasets

We first describe several fields that are included in two or more of the tables.

Name	Description
AOR [Area of Responsibility] ¹²	The ICE field office responsible for the enforcement action. In the case of detainees, this is the field office for the area in which the jail or prison receiving the detainee is located. For removals, our best guess is that this indicates the arresting field office, not the field office covering the port of departure. The “area of responsibility” refers to the states and counties the field office covers; the Deportation Data Project provides a list and shapefiles of the areas of responsibility.
Apprehension Method	How the arrest took place, with the most important distinction being between arrests that take place in prisons and jails under ICE’s Criminal Alien Program (CAP) and arrests that take place elsewhere. “Probation and parole” arrests do not take place in jails or prisons but are of people convicted of crimes who are tracked through partnerships with local law enforcement after their release.¹³ Similarly, noncitizens in immigration court proceedings may be placed into ICE’s Alternatives to Detention (ATD) program, in which they are released on their own recognizance but tracked by ICE and then arrested for detention and removal.¹⁴ Beyond these, ICE classifies “at large” arrests as “located,” which refers to “fugitives arrested by Fugitive Operations,” a unit of ERO; and “non-custodial,” which refers to “all street arrests.”¹⁵ Finally, many arrests stem from 287(g) partnerships, which may either involve a partnership with a jail or with local police and therefore may include either custodial or at-large arrests.

¹²Apprehension AOR (arrests), Docket (removals), Facility AOR (detainees), and Responsible AOR (encounters).

¹³“identifies, investigates, locates and arrests at large noncitizens within the United States, including larger-scale enforcement operations...” <https://www.ice.gov/doclib/eoy/iceAnnualReportFY2024.pdf> and “use intelligence-based information and leads to locate and arrest aliens” <https://www.ice.gov/doclib/news/library/factsheets/pdf/fugops.pdf>

¹⁴ICE collects data on noncitizens in the ATD program and has released it in the past, but our dataset does not include them.

¹⁵https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/cap_ice_4-15-14_0.pdf; <https://www.ice.gov/sites/default/files/documents/Report/2017/iceEndOfYearFY2017.pdf>, https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/changing_patterns_of_interior_immigration_enforcement_in_the_united_states.pdf, and <https://www.dhs.gov/sites/default/files/2023-03/U.S.%20IMMIGRATION%20AND%20CUSTOMS%20ENFORCEMENT%20Remediated.pdf>

Name	Description
Case Category ¹⁶	Combined information on case type and status at the time of arrest. ¹⁷
Case Status	Includes some information about case type and status, most likely as of the date that the data was extracted.
Case Threat Level	We believe this stands for removal case threat level based on conviction; sometimes this field is also called case threat level. We believe that these levels correspond to the three levels laid out in a 2011 ICE memorandum (https://www.ice.gov/doclib/news/releases/2011/110302washingtondc.pdf): • Level 1 offenders: aliens convicted of 'aggravated felonies,' as defined in § 101(a)(43) of the Immigration and Nationality Act, or two or more crimes each punishable by more than one year, commonly referred to as 'felonies'; • Level 2 offenders: aliens convicted of any felony or three or more crimes each punishable by less than one year, commonly referred to as 'misdemeanors'; and • Level 3 offenders: aliens convicted of crimes punishable by less than one year." When this field is missing, that is meaningful: it indicates that ICE has no record of a criminal conviction.
Criminality ¹⁸	This takes three values, corresponding to whether an individual has at least one criminal conviction, no criminal convictions but at least one criminal charge, or no charges or convictions ("other immigration violator"). The "pending charges" category does not necessarily indicate that charges have been filed against an individual or even that charges <i>could</i> still be filed. We believe that individuals who have been arrested and booked for a crime, but for whom a prosecutor has not filed or has declined to file charges, or for whom the statute of limitations has expired, may still be recorded as having pending charges. Charges and convictions include both immigration-related and non-immigration-related crimes.
Departed Date	Date of actual departure or deportation from the United States.
Departure Country	Country to which the individual was deported. To identify removals in which noncitizens were sent to a country other than the one in which they were born or are citizens ("third country removals"), this field can be compared with citizenship country and birth country fields.

¹⁶Named Case Category (arrests), Case Category Time of Arrest (removals), and Case Category Time of Apprehension (detainers).

¹⁷See <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epdf/10.1177/233150241500300402> pp. 335-36 for descriptions of the values.

¹⁸This variable is named Apprehension, Book In, Case, Detainer Prepared, or Encounter Criminality depending on the table.

Name	Description
Detention Facility	Note that this field means different things in the detainers and detentions data. In the detainers data, this is the name of the jail or prison to which ICE made a detainer request, where a person was being held on criminal grounds (either pretrial or when serving a sentence). In the detentions data, this is the name of the immigration detention facility in which ICE was holding the person (on civil immigration grounds).
Detention Facility Code	Short alphabetic code for detention facility, sometimes known as DETLOC. Note that this field means different things in the detainers and detention data; see detention facility field description.
Entry Date	Date of most recent entry into the United States.
Entry Status	We are unsure how this field is used.
Felon	A flag indicating that ICE believes a person has an aggravated felony conviction; we are unsure whether this field is being used.
Final Order Date	Date of the final order of removal, which means an order of removal that was either affirmed on appeal or not appealed, or that was issued without the involvement of an immigration judge (for example, in expedited removal proceedings).
Final Order (Yes/no)	This indicates whether an individual has a final order of removal, which means an order of removal that was either affirmed on appeal or not appealed, or that was issued without the involvement of an immigration judge (for example, in expedited removal). See also the final order date field.
Final Program	The program associated with the arrest (not necessarily performed by ICE), which might also be described as the category of arrest (see the related Apprehension Method field above). The values show the range of these categories, but key examples are the Criminal Alien Program, which involves arrests in prisons and jails, the 287(g) program, which involves collaboration with a local agency, and Border Patrol.
Final Program Group	Always ICE in encounters and arrests, since the dataset includes only encounters and arrests conducted by ICE. In removals and detentions, this is either ICE or CBP, since ICE detains and removes many people initially apprehended by CBP.
Most Serious Conviction (MSC) Charge	The most serious criminal conviction that ICE has recorded for the individual. These appear to be standardized crime descriptions, likely drawn from the National Crime Information Center.
MSC Charge Code	The National Crime Information Center code corresponding to the "Most Serious Criminal Conviction" description.
MSC Charge Date	The date of the charge for the conviction described in "Most Serious Criminal Conviction."

Name	Description
MSC Conviction Date	The date of “Most Serious Criminal Conviction” (see description of that field).
Port of Departure	Final place person was deported from.
Processing Disposition	We are unsure how to understand the values in this field, especially in relation to case category.
Unique Identifier	Anonymized unique individual identifier based on Alien Registration Number (A-number). A-numbers are assigned to noncitizens by ICE or USCIS; undocumented noncitizens who have not interacted with the U.S. government, as well as people on nonimmigrant visas (i.e. people who do not intend to remain in the United States) typically do not have A-numbers.

In addition, there are four self-explanatory columns: Birth Country, Birth Year, Citizenship Country, and Sex.

SM. 2 Fields only in the arrests table

Name	Description
Apprehension Site Landmark	Either an actual location or an ICE division associated with an arrest. See https://uwchr.github.io/ice-enforce/landmarks.html for details.

SM. 3 Fields only in detainers table

Name	Description
Aggravated Felony (Yes/no)	A flag indicating that ICE believes a person has an aggravated felony conviction; we are unsure whether this field is being used.
Biometric Match (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Criminal Street Gang (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Deportation Ordered (Yes/no)	Indicates whether the individual was ordered removed; where possible, we would rely on the final order date field instead.

Name	Description
Detainer Lift Reason	Reason detainer lifted. The key information here concerns whether the person was booked into immigration detention as a result of the detainer or the detainer was lifted for a different reason (for example, ICE decided not to pursue the case or the jail declined to honor the detainer).
Detainer Prep Threat Level	This is similar to the conviction-based threat level used in the other tables, but it appears to depend on predictions that pending criminal charges will result in convictions; many people are categorized as posing a threat (from 1 to 3) without actually having a conviction at the time of detainer issuance. Note that missingness in this field is meaningful because it indicates that ICE has no record of and likely does not predict a criminal conviction.
Detainer Prepare Date	Date on which detainer was issued/sent to the receiving jail/prison.
Detainer Type	Indicates whether the detainer asked the receiving facility to detain a person for additional time or to provide ICE with a notification of the planned release date. We are unsure how reliable this field is.
Facility City	City in which the jail/prison that receives the detainer request is located. Note that this indicates a facility holding someone on criminal grounds (either pretrial or when serving a sentence); it is therefore not the same as the detention facility field in the detentions data, which indicates the facility in which ICE was detaining someone on immigration grounds.
Facility State	State of the jail/prison receiving the detainer request.
Federal Interest (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Illegal Entry (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Illegal Reentry (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Immigration Fraud (Yes/no)	Unknown.
MSC Sentence Days	Many people with convictions recorded nonetheless lack any entry in the sentence days, months or years field; as a result, we urge caution in interpreting these fields.
MSC Sentence Months	Many people with convictions recorded nonetheless lack any entry in the sentence days, months or years field; as a result, we urge caution in interpreting these fields.
MSC Sentence Years	Many people with convictions recorded nonetheless lack any entry in the sentence days, months or years field; as a result, we urge caution in interpreting these fields.

Name	Description
Multiple Prior MISD (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Order to Show Cause Served Date	Date of Notice to Appear (formerly called Order to Show Cause).
Order to Show Cause Served (Yes/no)	Whether a Notice to Appear (formerly called Order to Show Cause) was issued.
Other Removal Reason	Unknown.
Other Removal Reason (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Prior Felony (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Resume Custody (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Significant Risk (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Statements Made (Yes/no)	More than a quarter of entries are missing; use caution.
Time of Apprehension Current Program	The program associated with the arrest (not necessarily performed by ICE), which might also be described as the category of arrest. Key examples are the criminal alien program, which involves arrests in prisons and jails, the 287(g) program, which involves collaboration with a local agency, and border patrol.
Unlawful Attempt (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Unlawful Entry (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Violent Misdemeanor (Yes/no)	Unknown.
Visa (Yes/no)	

In addition, there are three self-explanatory fields: Apprehension County (this field is 100% missing), Apprehension Date, and Apprehension State.

SM. 4 Fields only in detention stints table

Name	Description
Bond Posted Amount	Amount in USD of the bond that was posted.
Bond Posted Date	Date that bond was posted to be released from detention.
Book In Date Time	This field marks the beginning of an individual's time in a particular detention center.
Detention Book Out Date Time	This field marks the end of an individual's time in a particular detention center. It is blank/missing where the individual was still detained in that detention center when the data was extracted. Note that this is the equivalent, for book-out, of the "Book in Date Time" field, even though it has the additional "Detention" prefix.
Detention Release Reason	This field provides the reason for release from a given detention center—most commonly transfer to another detention center.
Ethnicity	Operates as a flag for hispanic ethnicity.
Final Charge	This is an ICE description of the ground of deportability or inadmissibility with which the noncitizen is charged; it corresponds to the final charge section field, which contains the section of the Immigration and Nationality Act creating that charge.
Initial Bond Set Amount	Amount in USD of the bond set by either ICE or the immigration judge, but more likely the immigration judge because ICE sets bond relatively rarely.
Stay Book In Date Time	This field marks the beginning of a stay in detention--that is, an individual's full period in detention from book-in to book-out, regardless of the number of transfers.
Stay Book Out Date	This field marks the end of a stay in detention--that is, an individual's full period in detention from book-in to book-out, regardless of the number of transfers.
Stay Book Out Date Time	This field marks the end of a stay in detention--that is, an individual's full period in detention from book-in to book-out, regardless of the number of transfers. When this field is blank, the individual was still detained as of the date of extraction.
Stay Release Reason	This field provides the reason for release from the last detention center in an individual's stay. It should not be "transfer," since it marks the end of a stay--that is, an individual's full period in detention from book-in to book-out, regardless of the number of transfers. If missing, that should indicate that an individual remained detained as of the date of data extraction.

There are two additional, self-explanatory fields: Marital Status and Religion.

SM. 5 Fields only in the detention stays table

Name	Description
Book In Date Time First	Beginning of an individual's time in the first detention center of their stay in detention (processed data only).
Book In Date Time Last	Beginning of an individual's time in the last detention center of their stay in detention (processed data only).
Book In Date Time Longest	Beginning of an individual's time in the detention center in which they spent the longest period during their stay in detention (processed data only).
Book Out Date Time First	End of an individual's time in the first detention center of their stay in detention (processed data only). Note that the field that this draws from in the original data is called "detention book out date time."
Book Out Date Time Last	End of an individual's time in the last detention center of their stay in detention (processed data only). Note that the field that this draws from in the original data is called "detention book out date time."
Book Out Date Time Longest	End of an individual's time in the detention center in which they spent the longest period during their stay in detention (processed data only). Note that the field that this draws from in the original data is called "detention book out date time."
N stays	Number of stays for a given Unique ID.
N stints	Number of stints in a given stay.

SM. 6 Fields only in encounters table

Name	Description
Event Date	Date of encounter.
Event Landmark	Either an actual location or an ICE division associated with an arrest. See https://uwchr.github.io/ice-enforce/landmarks.html for details.
Event Type	The event type roughly tracks the "Apprehension method" field in the arrests data, though many encounters do not result in arrests.
Lead Event Type	Unknown.
Lead Source	Unknown.
Responsible Site	We believe that this typically indicates the docket control office, which is a sub-office within an area of responsibility; we do not know more details. Some discussion of docket control offices is available here: https://www.ice.gov/doclib/foia/dro_policy_memos/09684drofieldpolicymanual.pdf .

SM. 7 Fields only in removals table

Name	Description
Final Charge Code	This is an ICE code that corresponds to the section of the Immigration and Nationality Act noted in the final charge section field. We believe that the final charge section field is more commonly useful because it can be cross-referenced with the Immigration and Nationality Act.
Final Charge Section Code	This refers to the section of the Immigration and Nationality Act that describes the ground of inadmissibility or deportability under which the government is pursuing removal.
Final Program Code	The code for the program associated with the arrest (not necessarily performed by ICE), which might also be described as the category of arrest. The values show the range of these categories, but key examples are the criminal alien program, which involves arrests in prisons and jails, the 287(g) program, which involves collaboration with a local agency, and border patrol.
Latest Arrest Program Current	We are unsure why this is often missing and would recommend relying on the final program field instead.
Latest Arrest Program Current Code	We are unsure why this is often missing and would recommend relying on the final program field instead.
Latest Person Apprehension Date	Date of most recent arrest of the noncitizen.
MSC Criminal Charge Status	“Most Serious Criminal Conviction” status; nearly always “Convicted”, otherwise “Pending.”
MSC Criminal Charge Status Code	See above.
Prior Deport (Yes/no)	This is an indicator for whether an individual was previously removed. Any individual who was previously removed necessarily has a final order of removal.